THE AHMEDABAD VISION

- **Decentralisation begins at the districts:** Empowering the DCCs marks a serious shift from high-command culture
- **Reframing nationalism and secularism:** Congress is pitching 'unifying nationalism' against BJP's 'pseudo-nationalism' while grappling with how to back minorities without alienating Hindus
- **Social justice as strategy:** A caste census, stronger reservations and OBC outreach signal a bid to rebuild ground in states like UP through a new social coalition
- **From promises to proof:** 2025 as the year of organisational empowerment gives the party a clear accountability test, breaking from its past
- **Vision vs critique:** Tharoor's push for a hopeful, future-facing Congress exposes a core dilemma—can the party move beyond anti-BJP rhetoric to inspire younger, forward-looking voters?

session's most substantive proposition was an organisational blueprint. Recognising that cadre structure has atrophied in many states, the Congress announced a shift toward empowering District Congress Committees (DCCs). District presidents will now have a meaningful say in candidate selection, a reform aimed at instilling a more live connection to the ground. For a party long criticised for its command culture, this represents an ambitious attempt to change its operational DNA. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge's blunt message to inactive leaders—"Those who don't want to work should retire or rest"—signalled a growing realisation that organisational lethargy has contributed to its electoral struggles.

Perhaps the most nuanced element of the Ahmedabad session was the party's attempt to recalibrate its stand on two battlegrounds where it has lost space to the BJP: nationalism and the fraught communalism/ secularism debate. On the first, the 'Nyay Path' resolution drew a sharp distinction between Congress's 'unifying nationalism' to what it termed the BJP-RSS's 'pseudo-nationalism' that actually divides the country along religious, regional and linguistic lines.

On secularism, things seemed anodyne on the face of it: a postulation that the Congress ethos was "inspired by the age-old traditions of India". But behind closed doors, a more complex debate was unfolding. Rahul Gandhi reportedly urged the party not to shy away from explicitly mentioning Muslims, Christians or Sikhs at a time when "minorities are under attack". At this, some veterans cautioned this could potentially alienate Hindu voters, reflecting the party's ongoing struggle to find the right balance on religious issues. As a member of the Congress Working Committee (CWC) told INDIA TODAY, years of the Sangh Parivar's blanket campaign against 'pseudo-secularism' have left the Congress in a bind—losing traction with the majority community, who see it as indulging in minority appeasement, as well as with minorities, who doubt its commitment to their socioeconomic aspirations. "We still haven't arrived at a consistent narrative...even after Ahmedabad," he says.

Social justice presented a clearer canvas, emerging as a central pillar of the Congress's revival strategy, with the resolution pledging to strengthen reservations, conduct a nationwide caste census, and enact a central law for SC/ ST sub plans with guaranteed budgetary allocations proportionate to population. Rahul is said to have strongly urged the CWC to step up outreach to the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), arguing that this may pave the way for an electoral revival even in Uttar Pradesh, where the party has long been on the margins.

Behind the scenes, there was a robust debate on communalism. Rahul favoured a less timid stance, explicitly naming the affected minorities

The resolution laid out a broad policy vision, highlighting the Centre's failures across labour, women's rights, agriculture, economy and foreign policy. It accused the BJP of weakening labour laws, undermining MGNREGA, and using Aadhaar-linked payments to deny wages. While welcoming the 2023 Women's Reservation Bill, it criticised its delayed implementation and sought sub-quotas for Dalit, Adivasi and backward women. Economically, it contrasted the Congress's rights-based approach with the BJP's 'flawed policies', blaming price hikes and monopolies for hurting citizens and pushing MSMEs toward collapse. On agriculture, it promised MSP at 50 per cent above cost and a debt-free future for farmers. It also slammed the government for its handling of key foreign policy areas—China (for its incursions in Ladakh), the US (for not preventing tariffs) and Palestine (reaffirming support for a state)—while flagging growing radicalism in Bangladesh as a threat to the minorities there.

It was left to Shashi Tharoor, the eloquent Lok Sabha MP from Thiruvananthapuram, to offer a gentle critique of the session's dominant narratives as he urged the Congress to project itself as "a party of hope and positivity, not resentment and criticism, and as a party of the future, not just of the past". His intervention highlighted a fundamental tension within the Congress's revival strategy—the degree to which it should focus on attacking the BJP versus articulating its own positive vision.

In fact, for several Congress veter-